Four strategic sales were announced in financial year 2019–20: BPCL, Air India, CONCOR and SCI. The Air India sale was mainly to stop the operating sclerosis, with the government likely to write off much of equity and almost all the debt. However, BPCL, CONCOR and SCI were expected to garner more than Rs 75,000 crore from their stake sale. The Expression of Interest (EOI) for BPCL was first invited on 7 March 2020 and was postponed quite a few times. The last postponement was until 30 September 2020. Finally, the government received EOI for BPCL on 1 December 2020, though only three parties submitted their interest. These EOIs remained awaiting evaluation until December during financial year 2020–21. The EOI for CONCOR could not be issued during the year, while the invitation for SCI was issued in August 2020. EOI for Air India was also received in December. The government did not disclose the interested parties during the financial year. None of these strategic sales could proceed beyond issue of the preliminary memorandum and receipt of EOIs in two of the companies during the year.

The stake sale of LIC, though only a minority stake sale, was another major item on the disinvestment agenda during the year. This required quite a few amendments in the LIC Act. There are also some major issues connected to the valuation of LIC. The government placed the requisite amendments in the LIC Act by way of the Finance Bill, 2021. The issue of valuation could not be sorted out during the year. The LIC issue also remained on hold during 2020–21 and did not make any meaningful progress.

The government could realize only Rs 5781 crore until September 2020 against the mammoth target of Rs 2.10 lakh crore and Rs 18,896 crore until December 2020. Faced with the ground reality, the strategic sale in BPCL, CONCOR and SCI not proceeding very well and the LIC stake sale unlikely to materialize during the year, the target of Rs 2.10 lakh crore was scaled down to Rs 32,000 crore in Budget 2021–22 for revised estimates of